

India's UFC dream: Rising to glory or stumbling in the spotlight?

Indian UFC fighters face a tough journey, **balancing early hype with hard lessons**, as they strive for success on the global stage.

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Whenever MMA fighter Anshul Jubli posts on social media these days, the responses are almost instantaneous. This quick feedback is understandable. The 30-year-old from Uttarakhand became a social media sensation a couple of years ago, amassing over a million Instagram followers after winning Road to UFC and making history as the first Indian fighter to earn a contract with the world's premier MMA organisation, the UFC.

However, after two fights and two losses, much of the interaction on his social media is negative.

"It's almost a guarantee what the messages will say at this point. It will be some variation of '19 seconds,'" says Siddharth Singh, Anshul's coach and the founder of New Delhi's Crosstrain Fight Club, where Anshul began his MMA career.

The "19 seconds" jab refers to the length of Anshul's most recent UFC fight, which ended in a knockout loss to Australia's Quillan Salkild at UFC 312 in February. Some of the mockery has been overtly racist, while an out-of-context quote from Anshul — where he said he had to believe he could beat all-time great Khabib Nurmagomedov — has also been used to ridicule Indian fighting talent.

While Anshul bears much of the criticism, he's not the only Indian fighter to struggle on the international stage in recent months. In March, Puja Tomar — the only Indian fighter to have won a bout in the UFC — was submitted by armbar in her second fight at UFC.

The performance of other Indian fighters in various promotions is equally disheartening. Ritu Phogat, perhaps the most accomplished Indian wrestler (a Under-23 Worlds silver medallist) to transition into MMA, suffered her third straight loss at ONE Championship, submitting to a kneebar by Ayaka Miura. This marked Ritu's first fight after a two-year layoff, and her future in the sport now appears uncertain. In December of last year, five Indian fighters competed at Brave CF 92 in a series of matches billed as "India vs Pakistan" — and lost all of them.

As Indian fighters increasingly compete in some of the biggest international promotions, many are questioning whether this is the kind